

Leadership does not always begin when we feel ready. Sometimes it begins when we reconsider what we believe is possible, recognise what we already have, and take the first step.

When the rules of entry change

The barriers to entry into many fields have changed dramatically.

A generation ago, producing a professional music recording required expensive studio equipment, technical expertise, and access to established recording companies. Today, a young musician with a computer and the right software can produce work that reaches a global audience. Similarly, digital technologies have lowered the cost of starting a business, publishing ideas, accessing knowledge, and building professional networks.

The resources required to begin have changed. Yet our assumptions about what it takes to begin have not necessarily kept pace.

This creates an interesting paradox for emerging leaders. Opportunities to contribute, innovate, and influence are often more accessible than before, but many people continue to believe that they must first acquire more qualifications, gain greater recognition, secure additional resources, or obtain the endorsement of established authorities.

Some of these requirements are legitimate. Leadership does demand competence, judgement, accountability, and experience. But others are barriers we have accepted without examining whether they remain necessary.

The question, therefore, is not simply whether the barriers to entry have changed. It is whether our understanding of those barriers has changed with them.

Leadership beyond the expected path

Consider a newly appointed manager in an organisation undergoing digital transformation. The organisation has invested heavily in a new strategy, yet progress is slow. Established processes

remain in place, employees are uncertain about the changes, and the manager has limited authority, a small team, and little budget to work with. Senior executives are preoccupied with competing priorities, and there is no guarantee that a proposed intervention will succeed.

The conventional response might be to wait: for a larger budget, clearer direction, additional training, or explicit endorsement from senior management. Each of these could help. But waiting for all the conditions to align risks turning preparation into a permanent postponement of action.

Instead, the manager identifies a specific problem that can be addressed with the resources already available. They bring together a few willing colleagues, agree on a clear objective, and experiment with a small-scale solution. The initiative generates useful evidence, reveals unexpected capabilities within the team, and provides a practical basis for engaging senior management. What began as a modest intervention creates momentum for a broader change.

The manager's response illustrates three characteristics that matter in leadership: **initiative, intention, and innovation**.

Initiative means acting rather than waiting passively for circumstances to improve. Intention means moving beyond a general desire for change to establish a clear purpose and align one's actions with it. Innovation means finding alternative ways forward rather than assuming that established methods or existing resource constraints determine what is possible.

The manager did not wait for favourable conditions. They worked constructively within the circumstances they faced.

This is not an argument for disregarding preparation, organisational authority, or the legitimate concerns of others. Nor should every initiative proceed without adequate resources or a realistic assessment of risk. Rather, it recognises that the absence of ideal conditions does not necessarily make meaningful action impossible.

For new leaders, this distinction matters. They may not yet possess the authority, credibility, resources, or experience they believe leadership requires. Yet they may already have sufficient knowledge, relationships, and capabilities to make a worthwhile contribution.

Their challenge is to distinguish between what genuinely prevents action and what they have come to believe must be in place before action becomes possible.

The barriers we carry into leadership

This is where Worldview LOA offers a useful perspective.

The Worldview LOA framework focuses on three dimensions of executive judgement: Legitimacy, Relational Obligation, and Agency. Together, these dimensions help explain how people interpret their circumstances and determine how to respond.

The significance of these dimensions is that people do not respond to circumstances alone. They respond to circumstances as they understand them.

Two individuals can occupy similar positions, have comparable resources, and face the same organisational challenge, yet arrive at very different conclusions about what they can or should do. Their interpretations of legitimacy, obligation, and agency may differ.

For emerging leaders, these interpretations can either open possibilities or reinforce barriers.

Legitimacy: Do I have the right to act?

Legitimacy concerns the beliefs through which people evaluate what is appropriate, justified, acceptable, or worthy of support.

New leaders often enter organisations in which authority and credibility are associated with established positions, seniority, qualifications, or a history of achievement. These conventions can serve important purposes. They help organisations establish standards and allocate responsibility.

However, they can also become restrictive when emerging leaders interpret them as absolute prerequisites for contribution.

A newly appointed manager might believe that challenging an established process is inappropriate until they have spent several years in the organisation. An academic early in their career might hesitate to advance an original idea because established scholars have not yet endorsed it. An employee who identifies an opportunity for improvement might remain silent because they believe it is not their place to speak.

In each case, the perceived barrier is partly about legitimacy: Am I entitled to question this? Is it appropriate for me to act? Will my contribution be regarded as justified?

The important question is not whether new leaders should disregard authority or established standards. It is whether their understanding of legitimacy accurately reflects the situation.

Leadership requires the ability to recognise when existing rules and expectations provide necessary guidance—and when assumptions about who may contribute have become unnecessarily restrictive.

Relational Obligation: Who am I responsible to?

Leadership is never entirely an individual undertaking. Even when one person initiates an action, the consequences extend to other people.

Relational Obligation concerns the commitments and responsibilities people perceive in their relationships with others.

For new leaders, this dimension is particularly important because leadership transitions often involve uncertainty about relationships. They must establish credibility with colleagues, respond to the expectations of senior leaders, build trust with their teams, and determine how to work with people whose support they may not yet have secured.

These relationships can become perceived barriers. A new leader might avoid raising a difficult issue because they fear damaging a relationship. They might wait for approval from a particular individual rather than engage the colleagues already willing to help. Alternatively, they might focus so intensely on people who have withheld their support that they overlook those who are prepared to contribute.

The organisational example illustrates a different possibility: rather than waiting for a complete team or unanimous endorsement, the manager begins by working with a few willing colleagues.

Applied to leadership more broadly, this suggests that effective initiative depends not only on recognising one's own capabilities but also on recognising the capabilities and commitments of others.

This does not mean treating people as instruments for achieving one's objectives. Nor does it justify ignoring legitimate consultation, collective responsibility, or the potential consequences of a decision. Rather, it requires leaders to understand the relationships within which action becomes possible.

A new leader might ask: Whose contribution is already available to me? What responsibilities accompany my decision? Am I investing in the relationships that can help us move forward?

Leadership becomes more effective when people understand that they do not need to possess every capability themselves. They need to recognise, develop, and coordinate the capabilities available within their relationships.

Agency: What can I actually do?

Agency concerns how people perceive their capacity and possibilities for action within the circumstances they face.

It is particularly relevant when leaders confront limited resources, incomplete information, competing demands, or uncertainty about outcomes.

A common response to these conditions is to construct an imaginary arsenal of everything that would be needed to succeed. If only the team were larger, the budget more generous, the strategy clearer, the technology better, or the leader more experienced, then meaningful action could begin.

Sometimes these resources really are essential. But sometimes the expectation of having everything in place becomes a reason for postponing action indefinitely.

The more useful question is: What do you have?

For a new leader, the answer might include relevant experience, an understanding of a particular problem, access to a small but committed team, or the ability to bring people together around a shared objective.

These resources may be insufficient to accomplish the entire task. They may, however, be sufficient to take the first step.

Agency is not the belief that every obstacle can be overcome through determination. It is the capacity to distinguish between what is beyond one's control, what can be influenced, and what can be done now.

This distinction is critical. Without it, leaders risk confusing constraints with impossibilities. They may interpret uncertainty as evidence that action is premature, or interpret a lack of confidence as proof of a lack of capability.

The result is a form of self-limitation: the person waits for conditions to change before considering how their own actions might contribute to changing them.

Bringing the three dimensions together

Legitimacy, Relational Obligation, and Agency are analytically distinct, but they operate together in the judgements people make.

Consider a newly appointed leader who identifies a better way of working but faces resistance from established colleagues.

Their judgement may be shaped by questions of legitimacy: Is it appropriate for someone in my position to challenge the existing approach?

It may be shaped by relational obligation: What do I owe my colleagues, and how can I pursue improvement without disregarding the relationships on which our work depends?

And it may be shaped by agency: What can I realistically do with the authority, resources, and support available to me?

The answers influence whether the leader proceeds, delays, compromises, or abandons the idea.

This is why leadership development cannot be reduced to acquiring technical skills or learning a set of management techniques. People also need to examine the assumptions through which they interpret their roles, their relationships, and their capacity to act.

A leader may possess the necessary competence yet remain inactive because they do not regard themselves as entitled to intervene. Another may have sufficient authority but hesitate because they misunderstand their obligations to others. A third may recognise both the legitimacy of acting and the importance of doing so, yet underestimate their ability to make a difference.

Worldview LOA provides a way to examine these underlying judgements. It helps leaders move beyond the immediate question of what they should do and consider how their interpretation of the situation shapes the options they perceive.

A practical starting point for emerging leaders

The message is not that new leaders should simply be more confident or take greater risks. Confidence without judgement can be as problematic as excessive caution.

The more useful starting point is disciplined reflection.

When confronted by an obstacle, an emerging leader can ask three questions:

> **Legitimacy — What am I assuming about my right or authority to act?**
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> Which expectations are genuine requirements, and which may be inherited assumptions about who is entitled to contribute?
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> **Relational Obligation — Who is affected, and what responsibilities shape my response?**
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> Whose support, knowledge, or cooperation matters? Which relationships should I strengthen, and what obligations must I respect?
>
> **Agency — What can I do with what is available to me?**
>
> Which constraints are real? What capabilities and resources do I already possess? What responsible first step is possible, even if the entire path is not yet clear?

These questions do not guarantee success. They do, however, help distinguish between barriers that require a practical response and barriers sustained by unexamined assumptions.

They also encourage a more realistic understanding of leadership. A leader does not need to know everything, control every resource, or anticipate every outcome before beginning. The task is to make a considered judgement, act within one's responsibilities, and learn from what follows.

The leadership opportunity hidden in changing barriers

The barriers to entry into leadership are changing, just as they are changing in technology, business, education, and other fields. New tools and new forms of collaboration are creating opportunities for people to contribute in ways that were previously difficult or inaccessible.

Yet access to opportunity does not automatically translate into action.

People still interpret their circumstances through beliefs about what is legitimate, whom they are responsible to, and what they are capable of doing. Those beliefs can enable contribution, but they can also preserve limitations long after the conditions that created them have changed.

For emerging leaders, the task is therefore twofold: to understand the actual constraints of their environment and to examine the worldview through which those constraints are interpreted.

The practical questions are straightforward: **What do I have? Who do I have? Where am I?**

These are not questions about possessing everything necessary for success. They are questions about recognising the resources, relationships, and possibilities available in the present.

Leadership often begins when we stop treating our current position as a final verdict on what we can contribute. We may not control the circumstances in which we find ourselves, and we may not be fully prepared for everything that lies ahead. But we can examine our assumptions, recognise our responsibilities, and make a considered decision about the next step.

Transformation begins not with changing the world, but with changing the way we see it.